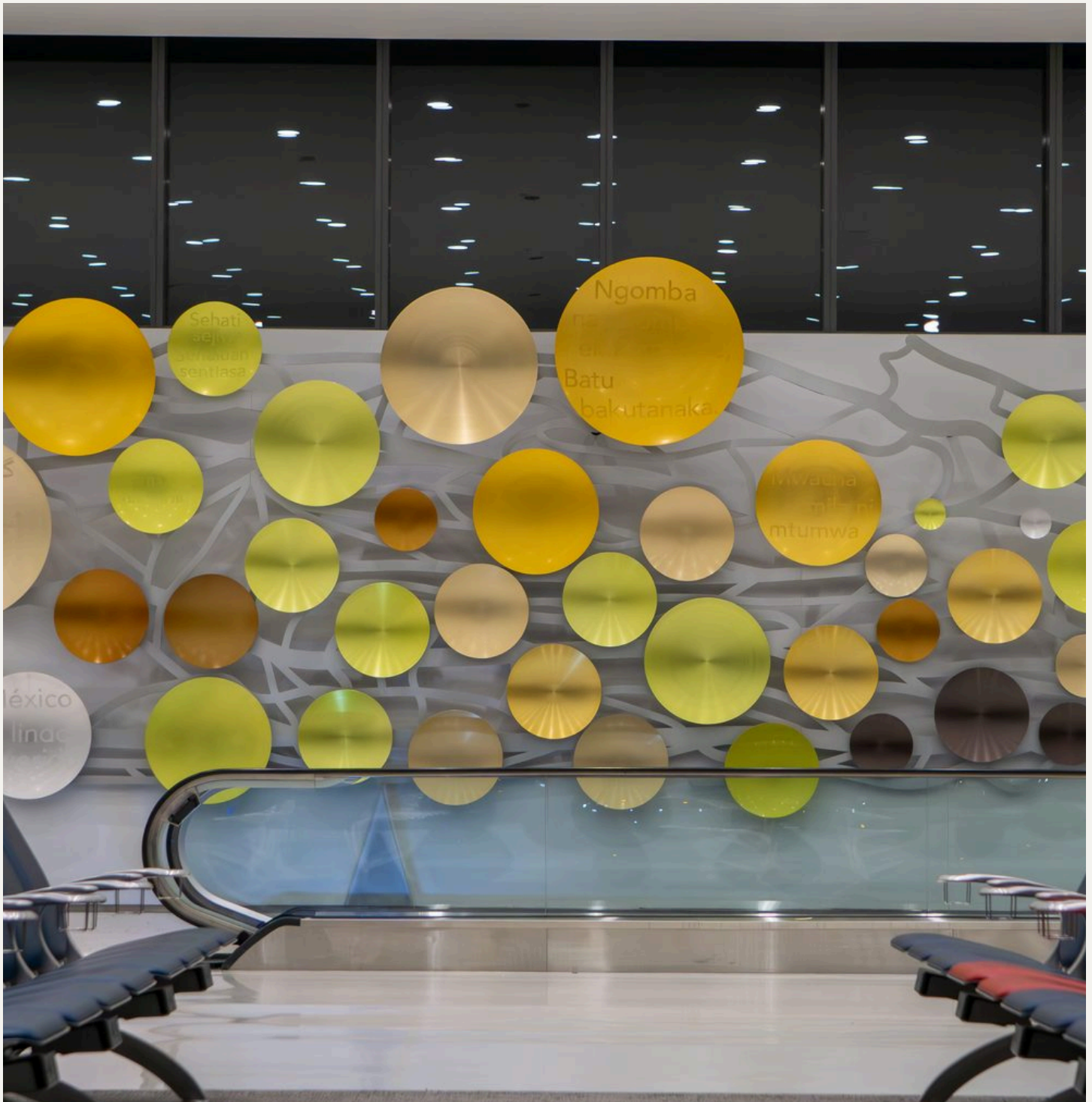


PUBLIC ART / 2023 / CHICAGO, IL

a murmuration

Public artwork, O'Hare Terminal 5



Three hundred and thirty feet of wall in Terminal 5, and nearly six hundred convex aluminum discs charting two centuries of immigration to Illinois.

THE WORK

Jina Valentine's a murmuration maps more than two centuries of immigration to the region now called Illinois across 330 feet of Terminal 5. Nearly six hundred discs each stand for an immigrant population by decade, sized to Census data and colored by continent of origin. Their arrangement comes from an adaptation of the BOIDS flocking algorithm, the movement of a starling murmuration, and the armatures follow the region's waterways, drawn from an early map narrated by an Indigenous mapmaker laid against a contemporary one. For all the data behind it, what it says to a traveller is simple: welcome.

THE MATERIAL QUESTION

Valentine wanted the discs at five different degrees of concavity. A single curvature would have been far cheaper to tool, and it would have flattened the work. The variation was the point, so the tooling had to carry it. Eighty discs also carry phrases of home, welcome, and community, and those had to read the way someone from that place would actually say them, not the way a dictionary would.

THE MAKING

Five separate tools, one for each curvature, with production at a volume where every disc still matched its set. Zinc plated steel and anodized aluminum were chosen for durability and finish stability in a high traffic terminal. The engraved phrases came from the artist's team working with embassies around the world to get each language right, down to the informal turns of phrase someone from that land would be used to hearing.

IN PLACE

A permanent installation, sequenced around live airport operations. What Valentine and her team did to bring those voices in was remarkable, and we were proud to give them a surface that will last.

DETAILS

Year

2023

Location

Chicago, IL

Category

Public Art

Materials

Zinc plated steel, anodized aluminum

CREDITS

Artist: Jina Valentine

Commissioned by DCASE and the Chicago Department of Aviation

Finishing: EH Schwab, Pioneer Metal, Gatto Metal

STUDIO

ChiLab Studio

Chicago, Illinois

Established 2013



01 A MURMURATION



02 A MURMURATION



03 A MURMURATION



04 A MURMURATION



05 A MURMURATION



06 A MURMURATION



07 A MURMURATION



08 A MURMURATION

Bring us a drawing, a model, or a hunch.

THE STUDIO

Specialty material projects for architecture, interior design, public art, and the fine arts.

ChiLab Studio, Chicago, Illinois. Established 2013.

WHAT WE DO

Metal casting

Glass

Finishes

Digital fabrication

Metal fabrication

Restoration

Project management

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